

Stress assignment without morphology in Portuguese: the qualityless vowel /0/ and the Metrically Marked Item

Shinya Makino

itakanro@g.ecc.u-tokyo.ac.jp

Abstract:

This paper offers an Optimality-Theoretic reinterpretation and synthesis of the author's earlier Japanese works (Makino 2010, 2012) on Portuguese stress patterns, focusing exclusively on the theoretical essentials. We put forward a prosody-only account of Portuguese word stress. The analysis reduces Portuguese stress to the interaction of **a qualityless vowel /0/ carrying one mora + metrically marked items (MMIs) + general metrical theory with OT constraints**. This /0/ is the musical "ghost note" — **beat** (temporal position) without **timbre** (quality) — which nevertheless shapes the **rhythm** (stress pattern): e.g. /0/ in *contador* /kont-a-dor-0/ vs. *contadora* /kont-a-dor-a/. MMIs are a class of **morpheme-sized elements** that, **when the condition is satisfied, render the final syllable of the prosodic word extrametrical**.

Principles

- Trochaic binary footing from the right edge
- The rightmost foot functions as the head foot

Parameter: determination of the right edge

- **Value 1:** final syllable — unmarked default
- **Value 2:** penultimate syllable — marked (when an MMI satisfies the condition)

Metrification is computed strictly from phonological information, together with a single piece of non-categorical lexical information — namely, the **MMI condition**. No reference to syntactic categories or to morphological bracketing is made at any point in the stress assignment process. This approach therefore **eliminates morphology from stress computation proper** and unifies items such as *contador*, *contadora*, *falava*, *falávamos*, *faláveis*, *número*, *numeroso*, *numérico*, *sobre* and *após* under one minimal mechanism.

©2025 Shinya Makino. This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (CC BY 4.0).

0. Abbreviations

The abbreviations, symbols and diacritics used in this paper are as follows:

PrWd = prosodic word; **Ft** = foot; **HdFt** = head foot; **MMI** = *metrically marked morpheme*; **$\sigma_{\text{final_MMI}}$** = the syllable whose nucleus is the final vowel of an MMI; **L** = light syllable; **H** = heavy syllable

// = underlying representation; - = morpheme boundary; /0/ = qualityless vowel with one mora; → = derivation; . = syllable boundary; Ċ (e.g. ɾ, ɳ, ʂ) = consonantal syllabic nucleus that arises from the association of a consonant with the mora contributed by /0/; () = footing; ' = primary stress; , = secondary stress; [] = surface representation; # = word boundary; σ = syllable

FTBIN = foot binarity; **TROCHEE** = trochaic foot; **ALIGN-R(Ft, PrWd)** = align the right edge of each foot with the prosodic word; **ALIGN-R(Ft, $\sigma_{\text{final_MMI}}$)** = align the right edge of the foot with the syllable whose nucleus is the final vowel of an MMI; **ALIGN-R(HdFt, PrWd)** = align the right edge of the head foot with prosodic word; **PARSE(σ)** = parse every syllable into a foot; ***CLASH** = avoid a stress clash; **#WSP** = weight to stress principle

1. The qualityless vowel /0/

A **qualityless** vowel /0/ that carries **one mora** in underlying representations is assumed — e.g. *contador* /kont-a-dor-0/ (cf. *contadora* /kont-a-dor-a/); *jacaré* /zakare-0/; *trabalhar* /trabaɫ-a-r0/; *trabalharmos* /trabaɫ-a-r0-mos/; *após* /a-pɔs0/; *até* /atɛ0/. This vowel /0/ is the musical "**ghost note**" — **beat** (temporal position) without **timbre** (quality) — which nevertheless shapes the **rhythm** (stress pattern). It is a purely phonological entity, serving various morphological purposes: in *contador* /kont-a-dor-0/, the /0/ functions as the thematic vowel — the stem vowel or *índice temático* (stem marker) — just as /a/ does in *contadora* /kont-a-dor-a/. On the other hand, it forms part of the infinitive or future subjunctive suffix /-r0/ in *trabalhar* /trabaɫ-a-r0/, and likewise occurs in the preposition *até* /atɛ0/, which does not display any internal morphological structure.

Both strong–weak alternation and high–low alternation require at least two distinct temporal positions. Without distinct temporal positions, neither strong–weak alternation nor high–low alternation can occur. Conversely, distinct temporal positions do not presuppose either strength or height. In other words, distinct temporal positions are a prerequisite for strong–weak and high–low alternations, but not vice versa. It follows that temporal positions can exist independently of strength or height. If a stress pattern is defined as the iterative alternation of strong and weak beats

in time, then both strong beats and weak beats require distinct temporal positions. If the stress — an alternation of strong and weak beats — falls on *-dor* in *contador*, there must necessarily exist within it a temporal position corresponding to the weak beat paired with the strong beat. In this way, positing /0/ is grounded in both the primacy of temporal positions for strong–weak alternation and the very definition of the stress pattern. Therefore, the postulation of /0/ is not an ad hoc assumption but a necessary requirement of a stress theory based on the metrical foot.

2. Postulation of the MMI

It is also assumed that there exists a class of *metrically marked items* (MMIs). These are **morpheme-sized forms** that are lexically specified to **render the final syllable of the PrWd extrametrical** (i.e. excluded from footing), but **only when their own final vowel serves as the nucleus of that penultimate syllable** — e.g. *-ic-* /-ik-/ in *académico* /akadēm-ik-o/; *-vel* /-vel/ in *agradável* /a-grad-a-vel-0/; *numer-* /numɛr-/ in *número* /numɛr-o/; *-va-* /-va-/ in *trabalhávamos* /trabaʎ-a-va-mos/; *-r-* /-r0-/ in *trabalhardes* /trabaʎ-a-r0-des/. **Whether a morpheme belongs to this class is independent of its morphosyntactic category.**

3. Unmarked metrification

Regardless of syntactic category or morphological structure, **iterative formation of trochaic binary feet proceeds from the final syllable of the PrWd towards the word-initial edge**, with the **rightmost foot** serving as the head and bearing **primary stress**:

possibilidade /pɔs-i-bil-i-dad-e/ → pɔ.si.bi.li.da.de → (,pɔ.si)(,bi.li)(ˈda.de) → [,pu.siβi.liˈða:.ði]
contador /kont-a-dor-0/ → kon.ta.do.ɾ → (,kon.ta)(ˈdo.ɾ) → [,kõ.tɐˈðo:r]
contadora /kont-a-dor-a/ → kon.ta.do.ra → (,kon.ta)(ˈdo.ra) → [,kõ.tɐˈðo:.rɐ]
coração /korason-0/ → ko.ra.so.ɳ → (,ko.ra)(ˈso.ɳ) → [,ku.rɐˈsẽũ]
parabéns /para-ben-0-s/ → pa.ra.be.ɳ → (,pa.ra)(ˈbe.ɳ) → [,pɐ.rɐˈβẽj̃]
jacaré /ʒakare-0/ → ʒa.ka.rɛ.0 → (,ʒa.ka)(ˈrɛ.0) → [,ʒɐ.kɐˈrɛ:]
trabalhamos /trabaʎ-a-mos/ → tra.ba.ʎa.mos → (,tra.ba)(ˈʎa.mos) → [,trɐ.βɐˈʎɐ:.muʃ]
trabalhais /trabaʎ-a-des/ → tra.ba.ʎa.des → (,tra.ba)(ˈʎa.des) → [,trɐ.βɐˈʎaj̃]
trabalhar /trabaʎ-a-r0/ → tra.ba.ʎa.ɾ → (,tra.ba)(ˈʎa.ɾ) → [,trɐ.βɐˈʎa:r]
sobre /sobre/ → so.bre → (ˈso.bre) → [ˈso:.βɾi]

This suggests the following constraints in interaction: **FTBIN; TROCHEE; ALIGN-R(Ft, PrWd); ALIGN-R(HdFt, PrWd)**.

4. Marked metrification

If the **final vowel of an MMI** serves as the **nucleus of the penultimate syllable of the PrWd**, the same iterative formation of trochaic binary feet proceeds **from that penultimate syllable — rather than from the final syllable** — with the rightmost foot serving as the head foot and bearing primary stress; the final syllable is thus excluded from metrification and remains unstressed:

académico /akadem-**ik**-o/ → a.ka.dɛ.mi.ko → (,a.ka)(ˈdɛ.mi)ko → [,v.kɐˈðɛ:.mi.ku]
agradável /a-grad-a-**vel**-o/ → a.gra.da.ve.l̩ → (,a.gra)(ˈda.ve)l̩ → [,v.ɣɾɐˈða:.vɐl̩]
número /numɐr-o/ → nu.mɛ.ro → (ˈnu.mɛ)ro → [ˈnu:.mɨ.ru]
túnel /tunel-o/ → tu.ne.l̩ → (ˈtu.ne)l̩ → [ˈtu:.nɐl̩]
sótão /sɔtan-o/ → sɔ.tan.o → (ˈsɔ.tan)o → [ˈsɔ:.tẽũ]
trabalhá^{vamos} /trabaɫ-a-**va**-mos/ → tra.ba.ɫa.va.mos → (,tra.ba)(ˈɫa.va)mos
→ [,trɐ.βɐˈɫa:.vɐ.muʃ]
trabalhá^{veis} /trabaɫ-a-**va**-des/ → tra.ba.ɫa.va.des → (,tra.ba)(ˈɫa.va)des → [,trɐ.βɐˈɫa:.vɐiʃ]
trabalhardes /trabaɫ-a-**r0**-des/ → tra.ba.ɫa.r̩.des → (,tra.ba)(ˈɫa.r̩)des → [,trɐ.βɐˈɫa:r̩.ðiʃ]

By contrast, if the **final vowel of an MMI** does **not function as the nucleus of the penultimate syllable of the PrWd**, **unmarked metrification**, as described in Section 3, emerges:

atonicidade /a-tɔn-**ik**-i-dad-e/ → a.tɔ.ni.si.da.de → (,a.tɔ)(,ni.si)(ˈda.de) → [,v.tu.ni.siˈða:.ði]
numeroso /numɐr-oz-o/ → nu.mɛ.ro.zo → (,nu.mɛ)(ˈro.zo) → [,nu.mɨˈro:.zu]
trabalhava /trabaɫ-a-**va**/ → tra.ba.ɫa.va → (,tra.ba)(ˈɫa.va) → [,trɐ.βɐˈɫa:.vɐ]
trabalhar /trabaɫ-a-**r0**/ → tra.ba.ɫa.r̩ → (,tra.ba)(ˈɫa.r̩) → [,trɐ.βɐˈɫa:r̩]

When a PrWd contains more than one MMI, metrification proceeds from the final syllable of the MMI whose final vowel function as the nucleus of the penultimate syllable of the PrWd:

numérico /numɐr-**ik**-o/ → nu.mɛ.ri.ko → nu(ˈmɛ.ri)ko → [nuˈmɛ:.ri.ku]

All of the above suggests the ranking: **ALIGN-R(Ft, σ_{final}_MMI) >> ALIGN-R(Ft, PrWd)** and **ALIGN-R(HdFt, σ_{final}_MMI) >> ALIGN-R(HdFt, PrWd)**. Note that whereas syllabification refers also to morphological information, the metrification of syllable strings refers only to phonological information.

5. Stress clash avoidance (provisional)

When the metrification domain contains an **odd** number of syllables, to avoid a stress clash between a potential **word-initial unary foot** and the following **binary foot**, metrification is assumed to proceed as follows. These generalisations are **provisional** and call for further investigation.

5.1 Five or more syllables: only the leftmost foot is ternary

Only the **leftmost** foot is **ternary**; **subsequent** feet remain **binary** trochees:

papelaria /papel-ari-a/ → pa.pe.la.ri.a → (, **pa.pe.la**)('ri.a) → [,pɐ.pi.lɐ'ða:.ði]
computador /konput-a-dor-o/ → kon.pu.ta.do.ɾ → (, **kon.pu.ta**)('do.ɾ) → [,kõ.pu.tɐ'ðo:r]
entendimento /entend-i-ment-o/ → en.ten.di.men.to → (, **en.ten.di**)('men.to) → [,ẽ.tẽ.di'ẽ:.tu]

The constraint observations and violations of the winner and the losers are as follows:

Winner #($\sigma\sigma\sigma$)...#: **NO** *CLASH violation; **NO PARSE(σ) violation**; **ONE** FTBIN violation

Loser # σ ($\sigma\sigma$)...#: **NO** *CLASH violation; **ONE** PARSE(σ) violation; **NO FTBIN violation**

∴ PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN

Winner #($\sigma\sigma\sigma$)...#: **NO *CLASH violation**; **NO** PARSE(σ) violation; **ONE** FTBIN violation

Loser #(σ)($\sigma\sigma$)...#: **ONE *CLASH violation**; **NO** PARSE(σ) violation; **ONE** FTBIN violation

∴ *CLASH decides (tie-breaking).

This suggests the following constraints: **PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN; *CLASH**

5.2 Initial L-H exception: initial light syllable unfooted

If a **light initial syllable** is **immediately followed by a heavy syllable**, it remains **unfooted**:

levantamento /levant-a-ment-o/ → le.van.ta.men.to → **le**(, van.ta)('men.to) → [lĩ,vẽ.ta'mẽ:.tu]

Note that optional unary footing of the initial light syllable is not excluded, as in *levantamento* /levant-a-ment-o/ → **le**.van.ta.men.to → (, **le**)(, van.ta)('men.to) → [lĩ,vẽ.ta'mẽ:.tu].

The constraint observations and violations are as follows:

Winner # L (H.σ)...#:

NO *CLASH violation; **ONE PARSE(σ) violation**; NO FTBIN violation; **NO #WSP violation**

Loser # (L.H.σ)...#:

NO *CLASH violation; **NO PARSE(σ) violation**; ONE FTBIN violation; **ONE #WSP violation**

∴ **#WSP >> PARSE(σ)** — since PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN, as inferred in Section 5.1, the evaluation by FTBIN does not affect the evaluation by PARSE(σ).

Winner #L (H.σ)...#:

NO *CLASH violation; **ONE PARSE(σ) violation**; NO FTBIN violation; NO #WSP violation

Loser # (L)(H.σ)...#:

ONE *CLASH violation; **NO PARSE(σ) violation**; ONE FTBIN violation; NO #WSP violation

∴ ***CLASH >> PARSE(σ)** — since PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN, the evaluation by FTBIN does not affect the evaluation by PARSE(σ).

This suggests the following constraint ranking: ***CLASH, #WSP >> PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN**

5.3 Three syllables: initial syllable unfooted

The **initial** syllable is **not footed**:

peessoa /peso-a/ → **pe**.so.a → **pe**('so.a) → [**pi**'so:.ə]

doutores /dout-or-0-s/ → **dou**.to.r0s → **dou**('to.r0s) → [**do**'to:.ri]

pequeno /peken-o/ → **pe**.ke.no → **pe**('ke.no) → [**pi**'ke:.nu]

levar /lev-a-r0/ → **le**.va.ɾ → **le**('va.ɾ) → [**li**'va:r]

até /atε0/ → **a**.tε.0 → **a**('tε.0) → [**ɐ**'tε:]

após /apɔs0/ → **a**.pɔ.ʃ → **a**('pɔ.ʃ) → [**ɐ**'pɔ:ʃ]

Note that optional unary footing of the initial syllable, as in *levar* /lev-a-r0/ → le.va.ɾ → (le)('va.ɾ) → [li'va:r], is not excluded. The constraint observations and violations of the winner candidate and the loser candidates are as follows:

Winner #σ('σσ)#: **NO *CLASH violation**; **ONE PARSE(σ) violation**; NO FTBIN violation

Loser # (,σ)('σσ)#: **ONE *CLASH violation**; **NO PARSE(σ) violation**; ONE FTBIN violation

∴ ***CLASH >> PARSE(σ)** — since PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN, the evaluation by FTBIN does not affect the evaluation by PARSE(σ).

This also suggests the following constraint ranking: ***CLASH, #WSP >> PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN**

6. The constraint set (provisional)

From the discussion in Sections 3, 4 and 5, the following set of constraints and their rankings are inferred:

***CLASH, #WSP >> PARSE(σ) >> FTBIN;**

TROCHEE;

ALIGN-R(Ft, $\sigma_{\text{final_MMI}}$), >> ALIGN-R(Ft, PrWd);

ALIGN-R(HdFt, $\sigma_{\text{final_MMI}}$) >> ALIGN-R(HdFt, PrWd)

7. Plausibility of the /0/ hypothesis

Plural in *-es* [-iʃ] as *-0s*/ realisation

We analyse plurals such as *contadores* as /kont-a-dor-**0**-s/. In the singular *contador* /kont-a-dor-**0**/, the mora supplied by /0/ (μ_0) is associated with the final rhotic /-r/, yielding [,kõ.tɐ'ðo:r] at the surface level. In the plural, on the other hand, the /0/ in the sequence /-C**0**s/# surfaces as [i] through the linking of μ_0 to this inserted quality (orthographic *-es*), giving the surface form [,kõ.tɐ'ðo:ri]. This analysis avoids positing an underlying /e/ in the plural — as in /kont-a-dor-**e**-s/ — which would have to be deleted in the singular /kont-a-dor-**e**/ at the surface level. Such a move would be incompatible with the many lexical items that retain final /-e/ [-i] — e.g. *árvore*, *are*, *hectare*, *Zêzere* .

Northern EP corroboration: paragoge

In Northern varieties, words ending in /-r0/ or /-l0/ may surface as [-ri] ~ [-rĩ] or [-li] ~ [-lĩ]. For instance, the infinitive *comer* /kõm-e-**r0**/ may surface as [ku'me:ri] ~ [ku'me:rĩ], with paragodic [i] or [ĩ], rather than as the standard [ku'me:r]. In the standard variety, μ_0 is associated with [r], whereas in these Northern varieties **μ_0 is associated with the epenthetic quality [i] or [ĩ], with the stress pattern remaining unchanged**. The "ghost note" /0/ thus occasionally acquires timbre, becoming a "full note" [i] or [ĩ], without nevertheless altering the rhythm.

Cross-Romance corroboration: Portuguese vs. Spanish

The main stress position of the future subjunctive forms *trabalharmos* and *trabalhar* can be determined solely on the basis of phonological information, by analysing the **future subjunctive suffix -r** as the **MMI /-r0/ with /0/**:

trabalharmos /trabaʎ-a-**r0**-mos/ → tra.ba.ʎa.ʀ.mos → (,tra.ba)('ʎa.ʀ)mos

trabalhar /trabaʎ-a-**r0**/ → tra.ba.ʎa.ʀ → (,tra.ba)('ʎa.ʀ)

This future subjunctive suffix is **-re /-re/ with /e/** in Spanish, which is, like **-r /-r0/** in Portuguese, an **MMI** and is assumed to render the final syllable of the PrWd extrametrical:

trabajáremos /trabax-a-re-mos/ → tra.ba.xa.re.mos → (,tra.ba.)('xa.re)mos
trabajare /trabax-a-re/ → tra.ba.ja.re → (,tra.ba.)('xa.re)

From this, it becomes clear that, **in stress computation, the Portuguese "ghost note" /0/ functions in exactly the same way as the Spanish "full note" /e/.**

Theoretical parsimony: economy of representation

Under the theoretical framework of this paper, the stress-pattern opposition between the quasi-minimal pair *também* and *lambem* can be easily explained by the final /0/ in *também* /tan-ben-0/, which is absent from *lambem* /lanb-e-n/:

também /tan-ben0/ → tan.be.ŋ → tan('be.ŋ) → [tẽ'beĩ]
lambem /lanb-e-n/ → lan.ben → ('lan.ben) → [lẽ:beĩ]

The stress-pattern difference can thus be attributed solely to the difference in their segmental sequences. Without positing /0/, by contrast, one would have to assign additionally a lexically specified accent to *também*, thereby requiring two types of information in the lexicon: segmental and lexical-accentual.

8. Orthographic corollary

When **marked metrification** emerges due to an MMI, the stressed nucleus is **typically indicated orthographically** by an acute accent or a circumflex accent, since the outcome **deviates from the default stress position** — e.g. *âmbar*, *côdea*, *número*, *pêssego*, *sótão*, *túnel*, *académico*, *agradável*, *trabalhávamos*, *trabalháveis*. This close correlation suggests that **speakers' prosodic intuitions** about **stress location** are reflected in the standard orthography, thereby providing independent support for the analysis.

9. Conclusion

Thus, Portuguese stress can be entirely reduced to **qualityless vowel /0/ with one mora + metrically marked items + general metrical theory with OT constraints**, eliminating the need for morphologically-driven stress assignment. The principles and parameters of primary stress

assignment in Portuguese are as follows:

Principles

- Trochaic binary footing from the right edge
- The rightmost foot functions as the head foot

Parameter: determination of the right edge

- **Value 1:** final syllable — unmarked default
- **Value 2:** penultimate syllable — marked (when an MMI satisfies the condition)

Reference

- Makino, S. (2010). *Porutogarugo no meishi/keiyōshirui no kyōsei patān* [Stress patterns of Portuguese nouns and adjectives]. *Anais*, XXXIX (2009-2010), 21-35. Tóquio: Colóquio de Estudos Luso-Brasileiros.
- Makino, S. (2012). *Porutogarugo no teidōshikei ni okeru kyōsei fuyo no kisokusei to goiteki reigai* [Regularity of stress assignment and lexical exceptions in finite verb forms in Portuguese]. *Encontros Lusófonos*, (14), 14-23. Tokyo: Centro de Estudos Luso-Brasileiros, Sophia University.
- Mateus, M. H. M., Brito, A. M., Duarte, I. S., & Faria, I. H. (2003). *Gramática da Língua Portuguesa* (5^a ed., revista e aumentada). Lisboa: Editorial Caminho.
- Mateus, M. H. M., & d'Andrade, E. (2002). *The Phonology of Portuguese*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- McCarthy, J. J. (2008). *Doing Optimality Theory: Applying Theory to Data*. Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell.